The Story of Prince Mahajanaka

A storyboard retelling of the **Mahajanaka Jataka**, painted in **Cave 1, Ajanta** (c. late 5th century CE, Vakataka period)

21LEM301T – Indian Art Forms
CLA-II · Assignment 1 · Cave Paintings Storyboard (CO2)
Team: _____



1 A Kingdom Divided

In the city of Mithila, King Aritthajanaka was turned against his younger brother Polajanaka by false whispers. Polajanaka escaped, raised an army and killed the king in battle, seizing the throne.

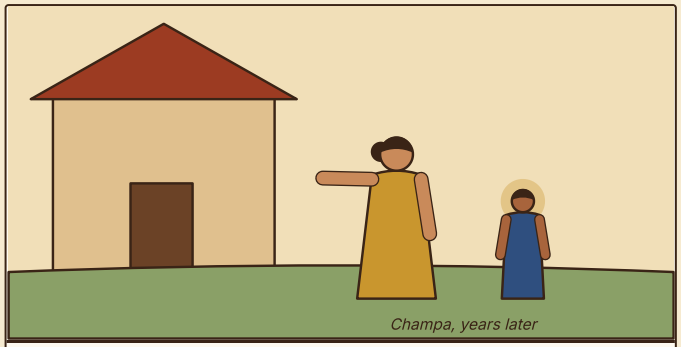
"The crown of Mithila is mine now!"



2 Flight by Night

The widowed queen, carrying the unborn prince, fled Mithila in disguise. The god Sakka (Indra), moved by her virtue, appeared as an old cart driver and carried her safely to the distant city of Champa.

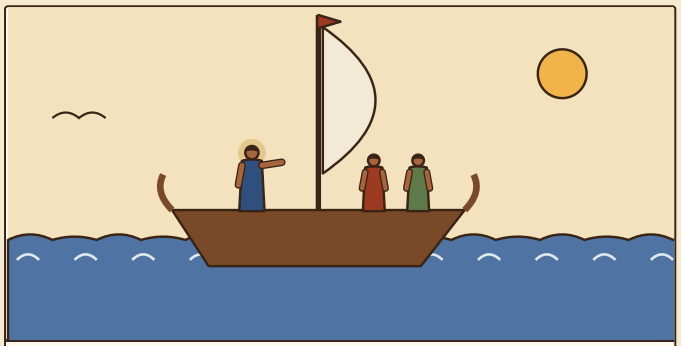
"Fear not, noble lady. I will take you where you will be safe."



3 The Prince Learns the Truth

Mahajanaka grew up in Champa, strong and learned. When other boys mocked him as "the widow's son", he pressed his mother, who finally told him he was the rightful heir of Mithila.

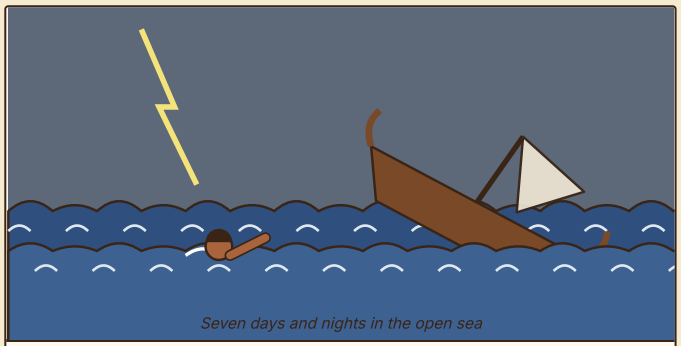
"My son, your father was king of Mithila. Your kingdom waits for you."



4 Setting Sail

Determined to win back his father's kingdom, the young prince joined merchants sailing for Suvarnabhumi (the "Golden Land") to earn the wealth he needed to raise an army.

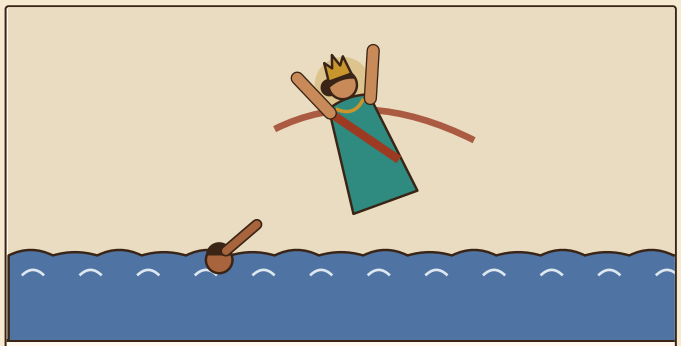
"With wealth from the Golden Land, I will reclaim Mithila."



5 The Shipwreck

In mid-ocean a storm broke the ship apart. The other sailors cried and perished, but Mahajanaka oiled his body, tied his clothes tight, leapt clear and swam. For seven days he kept swimming, never giving up.

"I will not stop striving, even if no shore is in sight."



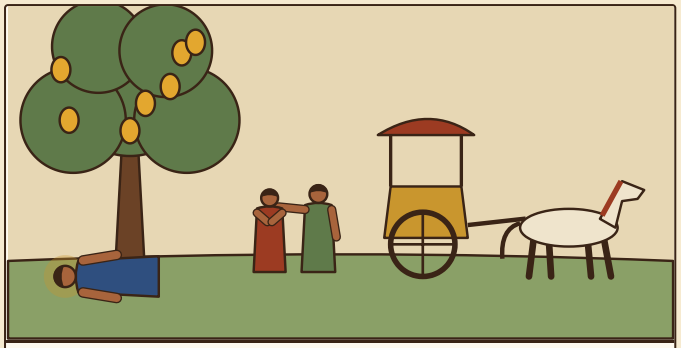
6 The Goddess Manimekhala

Manimekhala, guardian goddess of the sea, tested him: why swim where no shore can be seen? Moved by his answer about the value of effort, she lifted him in her arms and carried him through the air to Mithila.

"Who strives to the end is free of blame, even if he fails."

The Story of Prince Mahajanaka (continued)

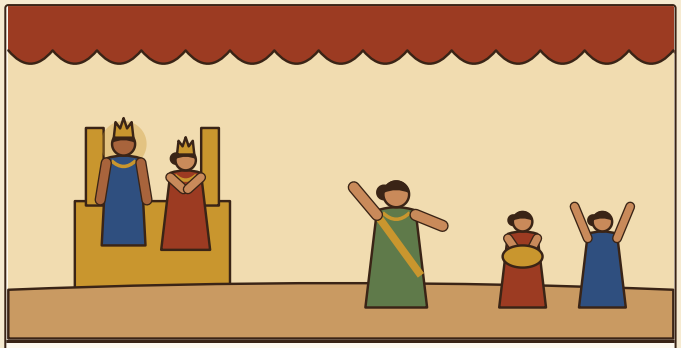
From shipwreck to kingship to renunciation: a Bodhisattva's lesson in effort and detachment



7 The Chariot Chooses

King Polajanaka had died without a son, leaving only Princess Sivali. The ministers sent out the royal festive chariot (phussaratha) with no driver. It circled the city and stopped beside a stranger sleeping under a mango tree.

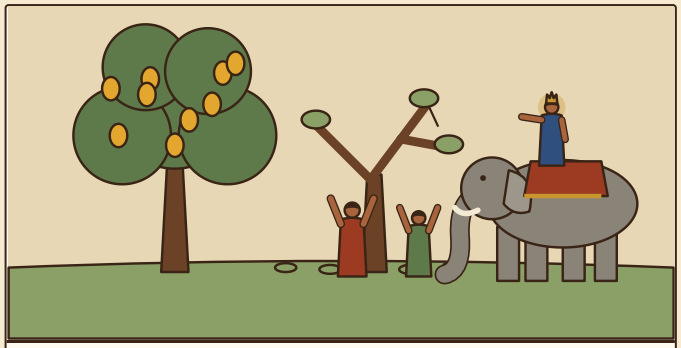
"This is the one the chariot has chosen!"



8 A Wise New King

Mahajanaka solved the riddles left by the old king, strung the mighty bow and found the hidden treasures. He married Princess Sivali and was crowned. The palace filled with music and dancers, the scene Ajanta's painters show so richly.

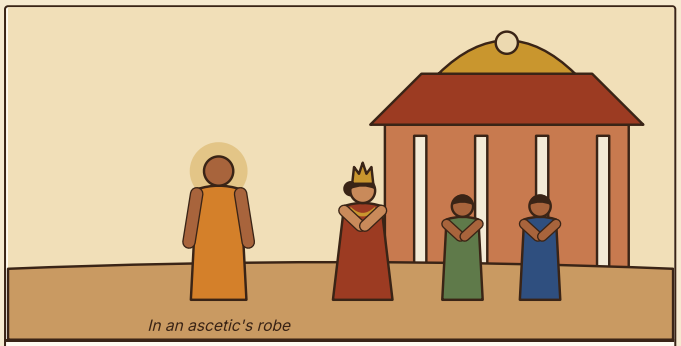
"Let Mithila be ruled with justice and kindness."



9 The Two Mango Trees

Returning from his garden, the king saw two mango trees. The one full of sweet fruit had been stripped and broken by greedy hands. The bare, fruitless one stood green and untouched. He understood that possessions bring danger and suffering.

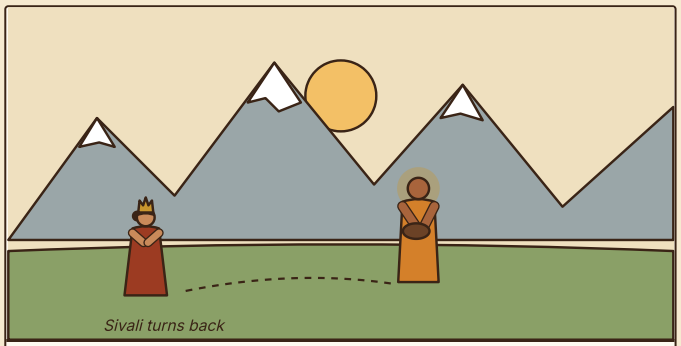
"The tree with fruit is broken; the tree without stands at peace."



10 The Great Renunciation

The king shaved his head, put on simple robes and left the palace with only a begging bowl. Queen Sivali and the people begged him to stay. She even set fire to houses to make him turn back, but he walked on calmly.

"Nothing that burns there is mine. I walk free."



11 Toward the Himalayas

Sivali followed him until they reached a fork in the road. Picking up a reed broken from its stem, he told her they could never be joined again. She returned to rule; he went to the Himalayas to meditate.

"Like this reed, I cannot return to the stem."

About the Painting

- **Where:** walls of the main hall, Cave 1, Ajanta (Maharashtra), a Buddhist monastery (vihara)
- **When:** c. late 5th century CE, under the Vakataka king Harishena
- **Technique:** tempera on dry lime plaster over a clay-and-straw base, with mineral pigments: red and yellow ochre, terre-verte, lamp black and imported lapis lazuli
- **Style:** continuous narration: many episodes flow across one wall without frames, with graceful figures, flowing lines and rich palace scenes
- **Jataka:** tales of the Buddha's past lives; here the Bodhisattva is born as Prince Mahajanaka

Moral: Never give up striving, and know when to let go. True freedom comes from detachment, not possessions.